

Ἰωάννης ὁ Λυδός

John the Lydian on Magistrates, Months, and Omens

eul_aid: vhw

Period: Ὀψιμαρχαία [Late Antique](#)

Dialect: Κοινή [Koine](#)

Domain: Ἱστορία [History](#)

Format: Πεζός [Prose](#)

John the Lydian was a Byzantine administrator and antiquarian writer from Lydia who lived from approximately 490 to the 560s CE. He served for nearly four decades in the praetorian prefect's office in Constantinople, where he witnessed major events such as the Nika Riots and the plague of 542. After retiring around 551 or 552 CE, he devoted himself to scholarship, producing works that blend personal experience with antiquarian research and often express a nostalgic view of the Roman past.

His three major works, all written in Greek prose, are **On the Magistracies of the Roman State**, a partially extant memoir and history of the bureaucracy; **On the Months**, an antiquarian study of the Roman calendar and festivals; and **On Portents**, a treatise on divination based on earlier sources.

John is a crucial source for the administrative and intellectual history of the sixth-century Eastern Roman Empire. His writings provide unique insider perspectives on the civil service, court life, and the preservation of classical knowledge, marked by a conservative attachment to Roman tradition.

Works (3)

- [Περὶ Οἰωνῶν · On Omens](#) · 106 passages
- [Περὶ τῶν Ἀρχόντων τοῦ Ῥωμαϊκοῦ Λαοῦ · On the Magistrates of the Roman People](#) · 127 passages
- [Περὶ Μηνῶν · On the Months](#) · 211 passages